

The River Remembers

Part One: The Boy by the River

John was born in the rainy season, in a small compound at the edge of Makurdi, where the Benue River bent like an elbow around the hills. His grandmother always said that a child born with thunder outside the window would grow up restless, and John proved her right before he could even walk properly.

By the time he was seven, John knew every path down to the water. He knew which rocks were slippery after rain and which fishermen would let him hold the net for a few minutes if he carried their buckets first. His mother sold tomatoes and dried fish at Wurukum market, and his father drove a commercial bus between Makurdi and Otukpo, gone most days before John woke and back most nights after he slept.

It was John's grandmother, Iyom, who raised him in the hours between. She was the one who taught him to separate good yams from bad ones by their smell, who told him stories about the war years and the flood of 1969, and who always said the same thing whenever he came home muddy from the river: "The water will teach you patience if you let it. If you fight it, it will only teach you fear."

John did not understand this for a long time. He thought patience was something old people invented to make children sit still.

Part Two: The First Test

When John turned twelve, the local primary school announced a common entrance examination that would decide who moved on to the good secondary schools in town and who would be left behind in the overcrowded classrooms with no desks. His father sat him down the week before the exam.

"You will not drive buses like me," his father said. It was not cruel, only tired. "You will not carry tomatoes like your mother. You will read books and you will go further than this compound."

John studied by lantern light because the power often failed in the evenings. He copied out timetables and multiplication tables until his wrist ached. He was afraid, though he told no one, that he would fail and prove his father's tiredness right.

On the day of the exam, John's pencil broke in the second hour. He raised his hand, and the invigilator, a stern woman with a scarf tied high on her head, walked over without a word and simply sharpened it herself with a blade she kept in her pocket. She did not smile, but she did not scold him either. John finished the exam with time to spare.

He passed. Not at the very top, but high enough that a letter came to the compound two months later, inviting him to a secondary school two towns away, one with a library and a science laboratory that actually had chemicals in the bottles.

Part Three: Leaving Home

Leaving was harder than passing the exam. John's mother packed his box with two changes of clothes, a tin of garri, and a photograph of the family taken at his cousin's wedding, the only photograph they owned. Iyom pressed a folded cloth into his palm at the motor park and said nothing, because she had already said everything she needed to say in twelve years of evenings by the river.

The hostel was loud in ways the compound never was. Forty boys in one room, buckets clanging at five in the morning, seniors calling out names for chores. John was homesick in a way that felt almost physical, a hollow space under his ribs that no amount of food could fill.

He found comfort in an unlikely place: the school's small stream, barely more than a ditch that ran behind the dormitory block. It was nothing like the Benue, but the sound of moving water at night reminded him enough of home that he slept easier for it.

His science teacher, Mr. Ogbeide, noticed him sitting there one evening and sat down beside him without asking permission.

"You miss the river," Mr. Ogbeide said. It was not a question.

"I miss knowing where I am," John admitted.

"That will pass," the teacher said. "Not because you forget, but because you grow large enough to carry two places inside you instead of one."

Part Four: Growing

The years at the secondary school changed John slowly, the way sediment changes a riverbed. He discovered he had a gift for mathematics that no one in his family had ever mentioned, because no one had ever had the chance to notice it. He also discovered he was terrible at football, which surprised him less.

There was a girl in the adjoining school, Ene, whom he met at an inter-school debate competition. She argued with a fierceness that made the judges lean forward in their seats, and afterward she told John, without any softness at all, that his rebuttal had been weak in the third minute. He found himself thinking about her rebuttal, and about her, for weeks afterward.

Not everything grew easily. In his third year, John's father's bus was involved in an accident on the Otukpo road. No one died, but the bus was written off, and with it went the family's only steady income for several months. John almost withdrew from school that term. It was Iyom, walking three hours to town with money she had been saving in a tin under her bed for reasons she never explained, who paid the difference.

"You do not stop climbing because the rope shakes," she told him. "You hold tighter and you keep climbing."

John never forgot the weight of that tin in his hands, lighter than it should have been for what it carried.

Part Five: The Decision

By his final year, John had to choose a path. The school counselor spoke of university courses the way market women spoke of produce, listing options without much feeling: engineering, medicine, law, accounting. John's father wanted medicine, because a doctor in the family meant security. His mother wanted whatever would bring him home most often.

John surprised them both by choosing civil engineering. He told his father it was because bridges and roads were what connected people to each other, what let buses like his father's travel safely between towns, what stopped rivers like the Benue from swallowing whole villages during flood season, as it nearly had when John was nine. His father was quiet for a long moment, then nodded, the way a man nods when he recognizes his own reasoning handed back to him in his son's voice.

The university was in a bigger city, further from the river than John had ever lived. He wrote long letters home in his first year, though the replies were slower because his mother had never learned to write easily and relied on a neighbor's son to help.

Part Six: The River Again

John returned home the first long holiday, four years after leaving for secondary school. The compound looked smaller than he remembered, the way childhood places always do. Iyom had grown thinner, but her voice was the same when she called him in from the veranda before he had even set down his box.

That evening, John walked down to the river alone. It had not changed at all, still bending like an elbow, still carrying its slow brown weight toward the confluence far south. He sat on the same rock he used to slip from as a boy and watched the water move past him with the patience Iyom had promised it would teach him.

He understood it now, or thought he did. The river did not fight the banks that shaped it. It simply kept moving, wearing down what needed to be worn down, carrying forward what needed to be carried, in its own time and no one else's.

Part Seven: What He Built

Years later, after his studies, after a difficult but honest job with a state road agency, after he had married Ene, who by then argued cases in a courtroom instead of a debate hall, John was sent back to Benue State to supervise the repair of a bridge that had washed out during a flood season worse than any in decades.

It was the same road his father used to drive. When the bridge was finished, John stood on it in the evening light and watched buses cross safely to the other side, their headlights sweeping the water below like searchlights over something that had once seemed unconquerable.

He thought of Iyom's tin under the bed, of Mr. Ogbeide sitting beside him at a ditch that was not a river, of his father's tired voice saying "you will go further than this compound." He thought of the pencil that broke during his very first exam, and the stranger who sharpened it without a word of blame.

None of it had been one single leap. It had been patience, taught slowly, the way the river had always meant to teach it, one season at a time, one crossing at a time, until a boy who once slipped on wet rocks became a man who built the bridge that let others cross safely over the same water that had shaped his whole life.

John never went looking for that particular rock again. He did not need to. He carried the river with him now, the way Mr. Ogbeide said he eventually would, large enough at last to hold both places inside him at once.

The End

Epilogue: The Next Season

Years after the bridge was finished, John and Ene had a daughter they named Iyom, after the grandmother who had walked three hours with a tin of coins to keep a boy's education alive. The younger Iyom grew up in a city far from the Benue River, in an apartment with steady electricity and a school with more books than John's secondary school library had ever held.

But every long holiday, John drove the family back to Makurdi, back past the bridge with his name quietly recorded in a state ledger somewhere, back to the compound that had grown smaller in his eyes but never in his heart. He would take his daughter down to the water and sit her on the same rock he used to slip from as a boy, careful now to hold her hand so history would not repeat itself too literally.

"The water will teach you patience if you let it," he told her, in the same words his grandmother had once used on him. "If you fight it, it will only teach you fear."

His daughter, only six, did not understand this yet. She only wanted to throw stones and watch the rings spread outward across the surface. John let her throw as many stones as she liked. He remembered being twelve and thinking patience was something old people invented to keep children still, and he did not correct her. Some lessons, he had learned, only arrive on their own schedule, carried in on the same slow current as everything else that mattered.

He watched the rings from her stones reach the far bank and disappear, and somewhere behind him, faintly, he thought he could still hear his grandmother's voice telling him to hold tighter and keep climbing.

The river kept moving, as it always had, patient with everyone who came to sit beside it, waiting for each of them in turn to understand. — End of Story —